



Winamp

The world's favourite music player keeps getting better and better. Here's some playing around with the myriad of Winamp's controls and options

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Winamp, surprisingly, has endured. It arrived sometime in 1997, and survived the slew of competing media players that came up after that—some of them Winamp clones—and kept adding features, such as support for video and much more. Now, in version 5.2, its music management and other features are more advanced and useful than ever. Here, we try and get a little into some of the lesser-known aspects of Winamp's features—going beyond just creating playlists and playing them, as it were.

Some Basics

On the front panel, the preamp is something like a volume control for the equaliser—when you set it right up, all the frequencies you control via the equaliser are pumped up, and the effect of sliding a particular frequency will be more pronounced. The other setting you might not know about is the "Auto" button: when you stumble upon an equaliser setting you like for a particular song—that is, a good equaliser-song match, select Presets > Save > Auto-load preset... The next time that song plays, the settings you chose will automatically load. Something interesting about equaliser presets: you can load a preset from a .eqf file—which is an exportable equaliser preset. So you make a setting and save it as a .eqf, then send it to someone—how cool is that?

Remix!

In the main window of the General Preferences page—acces-

sible by right-clicking anywhere in the Winamp window and choosing Options > Preferences—there's an option called "Allow multiple instances." Yes, you can have two Winamp windows open at the same time—and create your own remixes! You could, for example, play a drum track in one window and a slow classical track in another, making for a *jhankar-beat* rendition of Mozart (ugh!). Another, exotic use for multiple instances is to create an eerie, psychedelic reverb effect: you could enqueue the same track in both windows and start one just about half a second (or less, or more) later than the other. Try it!

Priority And Jitter

You'll find "Priority class" in the same window as above. The higher this setting, the greater the CPU power Winamp will use. Keep it at Idle or Normal for most purposes; if you have a slow computer, and opening a document makes a track skip, you might want to change it to High. Realtime is hardly ever recommended, unless your tracks keep skipping all the time.

Under Video in General Preferences, you'll see something called "Allow YV12 overlay mode." Without going into the details, checking this option allows Winamp to use the YV12 overlay mode, which can result in better video performance. Under Video, you'll also see "Synchronize video to screen refresh rate." This increases the fps of the video to reduce jitter and artefacts, if any.

Playing With Lists

Take a look at Predisix MusicMagic. The MusicMagic

Mixer is a library manager that can compute the key acoustical attributes in music tracks. It's sort of a power tool to create dynamic playlists. The software analyses your collection, and builds custom playlists from analysed songs! You need to be connected to the Net for this.

Why would you want a playlist to be created for you? Well, say you have a music collection that runs into thousands of songs. You're having a party and you need to create a long playlist that will last the length of the party or so. MusicMagic analyses your library using information from its database, which holds "acoustic fingerprints" of all the songs that have been analysed thus far. It gets these songs from folks like you: if you try and add a track that hasn't been analysed yet, MusicMagic analyses it and adds its fingerprint to the database. So what you do is, select a song you like, and press MusicMagic Mix. This will create a playlist full of tracks that are related acoustically to the song you chose as the base.

Syncing With Devices

Winamp has taken a cue from iTunes in its 5.2 version, and you can sync your device with Winamp. Under Portables > Advanced Sync Settings, you'll find options for the plugins that allow you to manage your iPod or other music device from within the Winamp Media Library. There's a button called "Edit query": it's pretty easy to use, and you can use it to configure what media types Winamp will sync with your portable device. For example, you can tell Winamp to only sync songs that are larger